

CHRIS J SHANKU

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Summary

Senior technology leader with 16 years across Microsoft, partners, and enterprise consulting, focused on pre-sales engineering, solution architecture, and practice leadership in financial services. At Microsoft, I led the first Generative AI case study across US FSI, consistently hit 96-97% of quota, and delivered executive briefings for Fortune 500 banking customers. Now leading iLink Digital's US FSI Practice while building AI agent systems that automate the operational side of running a sales practice.

I believe the best work happens when technology serves people, not the other way around. We are at a point where people crave authentic human interaction more than ever. Social media is full of fighting, AI-generated content is everywhere, and genuine connection is increasingly rare. Building trust begins with truth. That conviction runs through how I sell, how I lead, how I build, and how I tell stories on stages like The Moth. I am a builder, a seller, a storyteller, a proud dad to my five-year-old son Bruce, and above all a human being driven by curiosity, compassion, connection, gratitude, and leadership. I am all of these things, and that is what makes me effective.

Builder at heart. Award-winning storyteller. Relentless about making technology feel human.

Professional Experience

iLink Digital

Senior Director, AI + US Financial Services Practice Lead

Atlanta, GA | 2025 - present

- Building a \$4M annual revenue pipeline through consultative pre-sales, Microsoft co-sell motions, and direct enterprise engagement across banking, insurance, and capital markets.
- Designed and deployed AI-powered operational tools for the practice: The Ledger for relationship health across 100+ contacts, automated meeting prep, a voice-preserving email drafting agent with a review gate, and a follow-up engine that risk-scores every commitment. (AI for Ops)
- Built and rolled out iLink.Tools, a collection of Human + Agent-built customer-facing tools to accelerate our sales cycle. 100K+ page views since launch. (AI for Sales)
- Brokered direct introductions between iLink's C-suite and Microsoft's GM leadership across Insurance, Banking, and Capital Markets at Microsoft FabCon, turning that access into 15 qualified opportunities.
- Personally covered deep technical pre-sales conversations for customers and Microsoft sellers when no Business Unit specialist was available, building AI-powered research and demo tools to prepare and differentiate at the pace a dedicated technical pre-sales team would. (AI for Engineering)
- Built a Human + Multi-Agent verification system - dedicated QA, red-team/security, architecture, and responsible-AI review - that gated every one of those tools before it reached a customer or seller. (AI for Testing)
- Built a provenance-tracked AI research pipeline to arm live customer and Microsoft-seller conversations with account-specific proof points on same-day turnaround, human-verified before anything reached a customer. (AI for Research)
- Built an AI video-production pipeline - AI-drafted script, automated screen capture, cloned voice, digital-twin avatar, programmatic assembly - to produce product demos for customers and Microsoft sellers. (AI for Marketing)
- Identified a customer's inefficient manual support process (roughly 1,000 tickets/year to answer routine data questions) and built a natural-language-to-SQL agentic assistant against 600K+ records to replace it with self-service.

Microsoft

Senior Specialist, Data & AI (Banking)

Atlanta, GA | 2022 - 2025

- Delivered 97% Azure Data Services revenue in FY25 (97% FY24, 89% FY23).
- Led Banking in the FY24 Azure Arc-enablement Hero Motion, enabling >\$1.4M in net-new ADS; drove a \$1M Databricks win at a Midwest bank.
- Facilitated the Ally GenAI case study - the first GenAI use case across all of US FSI - plus Xome Data Modernization, both on Microsoft's Customer Stories.
- Named to Microsoft's Executive Briefing Center (EBC) speaker list for AI and Fabric; keynoted the Microsoft + OpenAI partnership to a top-200 exec audience.
- Only FSI representative selected for the Atlanta Innovation Hub Ambassadors program, giving tours and demos as a proxy Innovation Hub Architect.

Awards: Hero Award (Dec 2022) · Making It Happen nomination (Jan 2024)

Microsoft

Senior Technical Specialist, Intelligence / Power Platform / Power BI (FSI)

Kansas City, MO | 2017 - 2022

- The go-to Power BI expert across all of Financial Services; met or exceeded quota FY18-FY22 (96% VTT with 50% YoY growth in FY21).
- Hosted 40+ Power BI Dashboard-in-a-Day workshops; selected to speak at Power BI World Tour (Oct 2018).
- Delivered >1,000% VTT in FY20 as Power Platform Technical Specialist; led biweekly PBI SWAT sessions across Modern Work, Data & AI, and Biz Apps.

Awards: Peer Nominated Award (Sep 2019)

Valorem Consulting (now Valorem Reply)

Manager, Digital Insights

Kansas City, MO | 2016 - 2017

- Led the Modern Data Experience team (12 consultants, \$3M+ annual revenue) across business strategy, P&L, and all technical pre-sales; grew the practice by over 500%.
- Created ConsulTrain, an internal readiness program that upskilled consultants on customer engagement and consulting excellence.
- Hand-picked by Microsoft TSPs to deliver technical pre-sales on Power BI, Power Apps, Flow, Cortana Intelligence, and SQL 2016; sold \$1M+ to 15+ EPG and SMS&P clients.

Valorem Consulting

BI Solutions Consultant

Kansas City, MO | 2014 - 2016

- Lead Data & Analytics consultant for self-service BI delivery and technical pre-sales; sold and delivered \$150K+ of D&A revenue.
- Built Tabular SSAS cubes and Power BI dashboards with complex DAX; established company-wide credibility as the go-to BI reference.

Avanade

BI Architect / Offshore Manager / Delivery Lead

Atlanta, GA | 2009 - 2014

- Wore many hats at the intersection of Accenture's consulting discipline and Microsoft's technical innovation, delivering scalable BI on the SQL Server 2012 stack across complex stakeholder environments.
- Led offshore delivery teams (2-5 resources); resolved 500+ defects across 5-10 lines of business; trained dozens of new consultants through 30+-participant classroom seminars.

- Where I first learned to say "yes" to opportunity, even when it came disguised as uncertainty.

AI Portfolio

The Grove - Personal LifeOS · Multi-agent

The Grove is the personal life operating system I built for my family and me - a multi-agent harness that captures what matters across work, recovery, co-parenting, and health, then pushes the right nudge at the right moment. It runs on a homelab I own end to end, and it treats my own life like a product I ship to every day. thegrove.pro

Human in the Loop - Media · LinkedIn Live · Every Friday

Human in the Loop is a weekly LinkedIn Live show about building with AI - made with AI at every step, from research to the on-air graphics. Each episode works a real problem in the open instead of pitching a finished answer, so the audience sees the messy middle where a human still has to make the call. 15 episodes. humanintheloop.stream

iLink Tools - AI tools for an FSI sales team

iLink Tools is the internal suite I built with agents so an FSI sales team sells smarter - meeting prep, competitive intel, account research, and regulated-workflow patterns, all wired to the signals a seller actually acts on. Sixteen tools have shipped so far, each one earning its place by removing a real piece of manual work from the week. 16 tools built.

ilink.tools

Every demo below was built using a Human + Agent approach to marketing: digital-twin avatar, cloned voice, agent-driven screen capture, and a programmatically assembled edit.

twelfth.help - Recovery · Daily delivery

twelfth.help carries a daily recovery message to the person who needs it, the way the twelfth step asks us to carry it to the next one still struggling. It is a productized sibling of the step work I do every morning - free and open for anyone in recovery, with a managed track for the fellowships and programs that want it run for them. twelfth.help

WayFact - FSI data curation

WayFact is an FSI data-curation engine that turns raw market signal into verified, decision-ready fact. It runs as a standalone venture under TheGrove AI LLC, focused on the one thing regulated financial-services teams cannot outsource to a hallucinating model: knowing what is actually true. status: private beta.

Storytelling & Community

Award-winning storyteller and regular performer at The Moth. Stories draw on fatherhood, recovery, career pivots, and the courage to say yes before you know how.

The Moth: StorySLAM - Winner ("It's Time", Dec 2024); StorySLAM - 2nd Place ("The Divorce", Feb 2025); GrandSLAM - 9.0/10 ("I Knew You'd Come Back", Jun 2025).

Speaking & Mentoring: 12 engagements, 595+ reached, 2018-2026 span, 8 uga semesters.

Certifications

Microsoft: Azure AI Fundamentals, Azure Data Fundamentals, Power Platform Fundamentals, Microsoft 365 Fundamentals, Power BI Data Analyst, MCSE Data Management & Analytics, MCSA BI Reporting, Microsoft Certified Trainer

Kimball Group: Dimensional Modeling in Depth

Dale Carnegie: Present to Persuade, Powerful Conversations, Disagree Agreeably

Technical Skills

Cloud Platforms: Microsoft Azure, Microsoft 365, Google Workspace, GCP

AI / ML: Microsoft Foundry, Azure OpenAI, Anthropic Claude, Google Gemini, LangChain, pgvector, RAG architectures, AI agent frameworks, Agent-to-Agent, Agentic Systems, AI-Native SDLC, Loop Engineering, Harness Engineering, Context Engineering, Model Routing, OpenClaw, Hermes Agent

Data & Analytics: Microsoft Fabric, Power BI (11 yrs), BI Migrations, Database Migrations, SQL Server, CouchDB, PostgreSQL, Databricks, DAX, PowerQuery, Microsoft Purview, Azure Arc, Cosmos DB

Development: Python, JavaScript / TypeScript, React, FastAPI, .NET / C#, PowerShell

Automation: n8n, Power Automate, Power Platform, Docker, GitHub Actions

Pre-Sales: Solution architecture, Proposal development, Technical discovery, RFP response, Executive briefings, Partner enablement

Education

University of Georgia - Bachelor of Science, Mathematics (Athens, GA)